things from her children. Beating around the bush only brought confusion, she believed. Besides, she always said that children must learn the value of the things that were being given to them.

'You're right,' Papaji said as he stretched his legs. 'We'll also have to cut down on some other expenses.'

'I have a suggestion,' Maa said, and before she could say anything more, Papaji barged in, 'I don't want you to take up a job. We'll start saving. Don't worry.'

'But it won't be just any job,' Maa said in a convincing voice, 'it's what I've always wanted to do. I can get a B.Ed degree in a year, and then I can begin teaching in a school. Wherever you get posted, I can join a school there. God willing, the children and I can start going to the same school. Things will become easy then.'

For a while Papaji simply stared at Maa in admiration, then he broke the silence, 'All right, if that's what you want to do, go ahead.' As if on cue, an agitated Dada, stains of grease on his knickers, stomped into the living room and announced loudly, 'I need a new bicycle now! I'm tired of putting the chain on this one ten times a day.' They both looked at Dada and then at each other before exchanging a smile.

For the next few months, Maa worked her fingers to the bone managing things around the house while pursuing her degree simultaneously. She would get us ready for school, prepare breakfast for us and the dog, make us do our homework and prepare her own lesson plans. Dada and I only made things difficult for her without realizing the ordeal she was going through. Our incessant demands for snacks were met without any grimace. She would spend the evenings helping us with our homework, and when all of us had gone to sleep, she would burn the midnight oil studying for her classes. Her insurmountable patience never let her get agitated, a fact that I would realize much later in life. All this while, Papaji's savings spree held us in good stead. But it was at the cost of certain things, and all of us had to sacrifice. Our reliance on army-issued rations increased and expenses on extra messing had to be cut down considerably. No expensive clothes for a